

by the user such as e-mails sent and received, chat conversations, Web sites visited, and every keystroke typed. Activity reports can be sent to the e-mail address of the person who installs the program. AceSpy includes smart filtering technology that allows one to block activities, such as visiting some Web sites and using certain programs on the basis of keywords.

Alam says, "Many similar products have mushroomed in the market. But we continue to add new features to AceSpy and thus give value for money to customers. Testimonials from grateful parents, employers and spouses make us feel that we have done our bit for the world."

AceSpy sends e-mails and SMS alerts when the monitored people do something you don't want them to. It can take regular snapshots using a Web cam, for surveillance. AceSpy allows the customer—say, a concerned parent—to actually block an activity as it occurs. The software has won more than 20 awards from download sites including Tucows, SofoTex, WebAttack and TopShareware.



AceSpy followed the evolutionary model of the software development life cycle; it grew up with new functionalities over time

Zeeshan Alam
Co-owner
Retina-X Studios, USA



AceSpy can record IM chats and block specified content

Alam and Johns keep themselves updated with the latest laws passed regarding to spy software. Alam says, "On October 6, 2004, the US House of Representatives passed a bill, known as the 'Spy Act'. This bill simply refers to the installation of advertising or data gathering spyware without the computer owners' assent. While it's legal to install any program onto your own computer, it has always been illegal to install key loggers, spy software onto a machine without the owners' consent."

AceSpy costs \$34.97 (Rs 1,500) per license, which monitors one computer. This includes 50 free SMS credits. RXS has sold AceSpy and its other spy software to customers in over 35 countries, with 80 per cent of sales in the US itself.

All Part Of The Game

Alam, at present a hostelite, has to juggle college, study, work and play. He smiles, "I have a tight schedule. I attend college from 8 to 5 during the day, and at night—from 11 to 3—I work. As a result, I end up like Spiderman—perpetually late!"

Coding is Alam's Oxygen, as he puts it. "If I don't fire up the IDE (Integrated Development Environment) every day I feel as if some part of me is missing. I love to write programs, tackle a hidden bug, and design a fast algorithm. I'm

lucky I've been able to turn my hobby into a successful profession. I love writing spy programs and will continue to do so."

"My interests involve the Windows API (Application Programming Interface), sub-classing, hooking, multithreading, Socket programming, GUIs (Graphical User Interfaces), SQL, ADO, ADO.NET, graphics and animation programming," he adds.

Alam has been coding in VB (Visual Basic) for nearly seven years now—it's his favourite language. He's also proficient in several other languages. He informs us, "AceSpy is coded entirely in Visual Studio 97, specifically Visual Basic 6.0. Technically, AceSpy followed the evolutionary model of the software development life cycle; it grew up with new functionalities over time. The AceSpy code uses the Windows 32 API extensively."

In his words, "I wear multiple hats like any entrepreneur, sometimes killing a naughty bug, discussing money with an affiliate to handling a prospective customer." Alam tests and updates the software and releases new versions when required. He is the sole developer of all the RXS products, co-ordinating and executing the programming and providing technical support.

Takers For RXS

As Johns says, "What started as a part-time hobby has now become our livelihood. Our overall annual growth is roughly 300 per cent. It feels great to see our ideas come to life as winning products."

"Apart from the income from selling RXS products, we also get commission from selling other manufacturers' software (as at www.discount-spy-software.com). Our target customers include parents who want to protect their children from sexually explicit content, spouses who can find out if their partners are having cyber affairs, and employers who can prevent confidential information from leaking out," says Alam.

Keeping In Tune With The Times

Alam attributes the present turnover of RXS to the huge free traffic generated at their Web sites, courtesy search engine placements for keywords such as 'spy software', 'child monitoring', 'spouse monitoring', and so on. The duo routinely advertises on various Web sites including Hosting Bills, GetResponse Bills, Shareware Submissions, Shareware Advertising, Google Adwords, Overture, and Yahoo! Directory Listing.

"Microsoft ended mainstream support for VB6 in March 2005, so I'll soon need to upgrade the source code of AceSpy to the .NET framework. In fact, I shouldn't say 'upgrade'—I should say 'rewrite' the code, but in our field, this is a part of life and is inevitable! Besides, the algorithm will remain the same. So, AceSpy 4.0 may be in .NET anytime now," says Alam.

"Spy and system monitoring software will always be a popular choice for online users and I see the market only going up," Alam confidently sums up. ☒

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Write In

Done something just as geeky?
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